

CORE FORMULA

Notice the tension -> reflect side A -> reflect side B -> keep both respectful -> pause for correction or elaboration. -> Part of you wants one thing, and part of you is worried about the cost. -> You can see the upside, and you are also tracking the risk. -> You want to say yes, and you are noticing what it would cost. -> Two sides, one balanced sentence, then silence.

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Part of you wants one thing, and part of you is worried about the cost.

BEST FOR

- When someone sounds torn, ambivalent, or pulled between two values.
- When a debate is tipping into persuasion and the person needs to feel understood first.
- When both sides are real and neither should be mocked or dismissed.
- When someone keeps circling the same decision without landing.
- When you are tempted to argue one side and want to lower the pressure instead.
- Helping someone hear their own ambivalence clearly enough to think about it.

PHRASE BANK

Two-sided starters · Short one-liners

- "Part of you wants it, and part of you doesn't."
- "You're drawn to it, and also wary of it."
- "Yes and no, at the same time."
- "You want it, and it scares you a bit."
- "Half of you is in, half is holding back."
- "Tempted and cautious at once."
- "You like the idea, less the cost."

Torn between two feelings · Warm / personal

- "Part of you wants to move, and part of you is tired of starting over."
- "There's relief in the idea, and also some grief in it."
- "You can see why they acted that way, and it still hurt."
- "You love them, and you're worn out by it right now."
- "You're proud of how it went, and a bit sad it's ending."
- "It mattered to you, and it also cost you something."
- "You want to forgive it, and you haven't quite got there yet."

Work and decisions · Meeting / decision / status

- "You're sold on the direction, and not yet on the timeline."
- "You want to back it, and you're not sure about the budget."
- "It sounds like we're aligned on the goal, and still working out the how."
- "You think it's the right call, and you want more cover before you commit."
- "You'd take the role, and you're weighing what it would ask of you."
- "The plan makes sense on paper, and something about the pace worries you."
- "You want to ship it, and you don't want to rush it."

Naming the trade-off plainly · Clear / firm

- "You want the opportunity, and you don't want the version of yourself it might require."

- "You can see the upside, and you're also tracking the risk."
- "You want momentum, and you don't want to rush it."
- "You care about being fair, and you also don't want to be taken for granted."
- "You want to say yes, and you're noticing what it would cost."
- "It matters, and it also feels exhausting."
- "You want the change, and you're protecting what still matters."

Tentative openers and outs · Hedged / digital / low-pressure

- "I may be reading this wrong, but that seems like the key thread."
- "We can stay with that, or move on - your call."
- "Tell me if this is off: you want both, and neither feels free."
- "Maybe it's two things at once - the wanting and the worry."
- "If I've got this wrong, say so."
- "It might be that part of you agrees and part of you doesn't - does that fit?"
- "No need to land it now; it sounds like both are true."

Under tension or conflict · Pressured / emotional

- "You believe you're right, and you can see why they don't."
- "You want to hold your ground, and you don't want to lose them over it."
- "Part of you wants to fight it, and part of you just wants it over."
- "You're angry about it, and you still care what happens to them."
- "You want an apology, and you're not sure one would fix it."
- "You want to stay, and part of you has already left."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

- Weak: You are overthinking it.
Better: You are torn about it.
Best: Part of you wants the change, and part of you is protecting what still matters.
- Weak: Just pick one.
Better: There are two sides to it.
Best: You can see the upside, and you're also tracking the risk.
- Weak: So you don't know what you want.
Better: You want both things.
Best: You want the opportunity, and you don't want the version of yourself it might require.

DECISION TREE

If They add detail after your reflection

Stay on that thread; don't open a new one.
"So the harder part was being left with it."

If They pause thoughtfully

Wait. Let the silence do the work.

If They look uncomfortable or go flat

Release the move and lower the pressure.
"We don't have to stay with that."

If They ask you what to do

Switch to permission-based advice before offering anything.
"Do you want a thought, or just a sounding board?"

If They give a clear, single answer

Don't reflect two sides that aren't there. Move on.

If The situation needs action, not a mirror

Act or speak directly rather than decorating the conversation.

SCENARIOS

Casual conversation

Use the minimum viable move and keep the tone light. — "Part of you wants to go, and part of you would rather stay in."

Workplace conversation

Use concise, non-performative wording and avoid emotional overreach. — "You want to back the plan, and you want to pressure-test the timeline first."

Conflict or repair

Pair the reflection with validation or an autonomy release. — "You can see why they did it, and it still landed badly."

Digital message

One sentence only. Don't stack multiple prompts. — "Sounds like you want in, and the timing's the real problem - is that it?"

High-stakes context

Lead with direct clarity; add the reflection only if it lowers pressure and improves understanding. — "You need this handled today, and you also don't want it to blow up."

Someone circling a decision

Name both sides once, then leave room; don't push a resolution. — "You want to leave, and you don't want to have wasted the years."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- When one side involves immediate harm or coercion that has to be named directly.
- When the person has already made a clear decision and just needs practical support.
- When reflecting both sides would create false equivalence around abuse, risk, or deception.
- When they are giving short, flat answers and want the conversation to end.
- When the situation needs action, not a mirror.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the tension

Notice three moments today where someone sounds torn between two things. Just write down the two sides - don't respond yet.

Day 2 — Write five lines

Write five realistic situations where Double-Sided Reflection would help, capturing one sentence of what the person said in each.

Day 3 — Name both sides

For each of the five, draft one balanced sentence that names both live sides without picking a winner.

Day 4 — Cut by a third

Shorten each reflection by about 30 percent and make it more tentative than certain.

Day 5 — Add an out

Attach one recovery phrase to each, so the person can decline, correct, or move on freely.

Day 6 — Say it plainly

Read each line aloud in an ordinary voice. Cut anything that sounds like a therapist or a technique.

Day 7 — Use it once

In a real, low-stakes conversation, use it a single time, then stop and watch what happens.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I keep the other person's autonomy intact?
- Did I make one move, or stack several?
- Did my tone fit the relationship and the moment?
- Did I stop when the signal weakened?
- Did I follow their thread rather than my agenda?

- Would a simpler response have done the job?